

Considerations for Building Solidarity among Academic and Tech Workers

Thinking through access, positionality and limits to collective action

Noopur Raval*
New York University
United States
nar8914@nyu.edu

Rida Qadri
Google Research
United States
ridaqadri@gmail.com

Richmond Y Wong
University of California Berkeley
United States
ryw9@berkeley.edu

Tamara Kneese
Intel
United States
kneeset@gmail.com

Alex Hanna
Distributed Artificial Intelligence
Research Institute
United States
alexhanna@gmail.com

ABSTRACT

This panel reflects on the conditions of collaboration as well as the possibilities of solidarity between academic and tech workers by drawing on the experiences of panelists who have pondered questions of ethics, responsibility and values in technology-building from a range of positionalities within, adjacent to and outside of academic and technology organizations. As the proposal outlines, the panel will think through opportunities as well as risks for academic and tech workers to work towards progressive tech futures together but also the differences and impossibilities that arise with each position.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → *Computer supported cooperative work*; • **Social and professional topics** → **Computing profession**.

KEYWORDS

tech-work, solidarity, ethics

ACM Reference Format:

Noopur Raval, Rida Qadri, Richmond Y Wong, Tamara Kneese, and Alex Hanna. 2022. Considerations for Building Solidarity among Academic and Tech Workers: Thinking through access, positionality and limits to collective action. In *CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems Extended Abstracts (CHI '22 Extended Abstracts)*, April 29-May 5, 2022, New Orleans, LA, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 3 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3491101.3516511>

*All authors contributed equally to this research.

Permission to make digital or hard copies of part or all of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

CHI '22 Extended Abstracts, April 29-May 5, 2022, New Orleans, LA, USA

© 2022 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9156-6/22/04.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3491101.3516511>

1 INTRODUCTION

Conversations on the political economy of technological innovation and research have garnered interest across HCI conferences for some time now. Specifically, scholars have taken up issues such as the ethics of participatory research especially when studying communities with vast power differentials globally and recognizing the time, labor and insights shared by participants in such studies. Elsewhere, HCI scholars have questioned the implications of taking sponsorships from Big Tech corporations for organizing conferences as well as the politics of peer-reviewing papers emerging from industry research partnerships in the face of events such as the firing of the prominent Black scientist Timnit Gebru by Google most recently. Broadly, as Su et al[8] describe, through the mid-2000s, Silicon Valley and the city of San Francisco have also become symbolic of the transformative power and disruptive effects of techno-capital, tech workers and the ideologies of techno-preneurialism that have displaced existing communities and led to a meteoric rise in housing costs in the area. These issues coinciding with the rise of the Trump presidency in the US, the Cambridge Analytica scandal as well as a series of walkouts by tech workers opposing military and tech-surveillance partnerships forged by their organizations resulted in what is widely known as the Techlash[6][9]. This moment also coincided with a series of walkouts by tech workers related to gender and racial equality, particularly companies' practices handling sexual harassment. All of these movements within and outside tech-work organizations have reanimated questions around daily work and/as ethical practice and the potential for supporting progressive politics from within tech organizations. This dialog has also brought into sharp focus public thinking around the opportunities and constraints for nudging technological innovation in the direction of environmental, anti-racist and social justice goals, again, either from within or outside tech organizations[5]. Many early incisive critiques mounted during the Techlash as well as later in response to 'ethics washing' and the corporatization of diversity and inclusion in Big Tech, came from academics embedded in universities as well as academia-adjacent non-profits and independent research organizations. An important criticism leveled by those from the outside concerns the nature of proprietary technology, the amount of computing power[2][1] and

data corpuses required for research, non-disclosure agreements and various forms of privileged access that Big Tech researchers and workers have access to - thus making socio-technical research and critiques of AI/ML matters of privileged participation and access. As the panelists have noted in their own research[9], the worldviews that inform tech workers, academics and others' notions of change as well as the registers in which they articulate them are crucial to understanding the gaps and discontinuities in any shared vision of progressive socio-technical change[3][4]. These gaps may also point to technology and academic workers' positionalities as a point from where resistance/intervention/change can be enacted. Finally, unsurprisingly, both the centers of technological innovation as well as the communities critiquing it are firmly placed in and informed by Global North politics. Although there is some interest in "decolonizing" the university as well as tech thinking broadly, the Global South where the majority of the living and laboring world resides often appears as a passive entity that gets plugged into the techno-humanitarian discourse[7].

At least three relatively connected modes of response have emerged in the wake of the Techlash: 1) stories mining the hidden or invisibilized side of the Silicon Valley, 2) unionization and collectivization efforts in tech but also adjacent games and media organizations and 3) an internal and also broader conversation within Tech organizations around values in technology-building[4]. This panel draws on and utilizes our experiential standpoints as researchers of technological systems, tech workers and at times, designers and builders of large scale corporate technologies. We find our movements across corporate and academic settings and our respective experiments in enacting change from various positions (inside/outside, storytellers, interns, managers and more) as valuable points of departure for a collective dialog through this panel.

2 THEMATIC QUESTIONS

Following are the questions that the panelists will respond to:

- What do we learn by examining different modes of engagement or action in different spaces and at different levels?
- Many HCI tools to empower workers' voices and agency are often designed to support individuals and especially highly motivated individuals who bear the responsibility of surfacing uncomfortable and risky complaints. What can individual action accomplish and what are some ways of protecting and empowering individual action?
- What are some effective strategies for cross-field solidarities between academic and tech workers, including when supporting terminated or suspended workers?
- Similarly, what sensitivities and actions would we require to support actions or surface complaints from visa workers, contractors and especially precarious workers?
- If at all, can we "activate" and mobilize methods in design, participatory research and elsewhere in order to enact change within technology organizations? What are the limits?
- What forms of engagement and resistance can be done at a team level, or organizational level, or cross-organizational level?

- What are some challenges and opportunities for academic researchers working with tech workers to support cultural, organizational and political change?

3 GOALS AND OUTCOMES

The main goal of the panel is to examine the positionalities, commitments and audiences that shape thinking about technology and collective futures from within academia and industry-technology-work. We are also interested in thinking through individual and collective action, "soft action" such as space-creation, fostering regular dialogues with colleagues, strategies to manage conflict and work with dissensus, guidelines for self-preservation when registering complaints. While in conversation, we want to see what sharing stories - instances and episodes from our own as well as other people's (informants, colleagues, managers) experiences with proper anonymity and narrative responsibility can yield for building solidarity among tech and academic workers.

4 FORMAT

Our panel draws from critical and radical feminist, Black and Indigenous and queer traditions to mobilize personal storytelling and experiential accounts as powerful modes of surfacing how large social, political and technological shifts appear and bear upon individual and collective lives. We also find speaking from personal experience (not just our own but also the ones we have witnessed) as a possible method to carefully and respectfully relay accounts of risk and erasure as well as after-thoughts and after-feelings that may not be possible to record and report in empirical studies of tech work and workers. Thus, each panelist will speak for approximately ten minutes, responding to one of the questions and prompts listed in our proposal above, either relaying their own experiences or witness-accounts that made them.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We thank the CHI 2022 panel subcommittee for inviting us to submit this panel as well as our colleagues and interlocutors for the knowledge we will share. Each of us respectively stands on unceded occupied Indigenous lands. We express our debt and gratitude for the benefits we reap.

REFERENCES

- [1] J. Khadijah Abdurahman. 2020. On the moral collapse of Ai Ethics. <https://upfromthecracks.medium.com/on-the-moral-collapse-of-ai-ethics-791cbc7df872>
- [2] Rachel Bergmann and Sonja Solomun. 2021. A new AI lexicon: Sustainability. <https://medium.com/a-new-ai-lexicon/a-new-ai-lexicon-sustainability-d40fd714d396>
- [3] Abigail Boggs and Nick Mitchell. 2018. Critical university studies and the crisis consensus. *Feminist Studies* 44, 2 (2018), 432–463.
- [4] Alex Hanna. 2022. On racialized tech organizations and complaint: A goodbye to google. <https://alex-hanna.medium.com/on-racialized-tech-organizations-and-complaint-a-goodbye-to-google-43fd8045991d>
- [5] Karen Hao. 2020. We read the paper that forced Timnit Gebru out of Google. Here's what it says. *Retrieved January 21 (2020), 2021*.
- [6] Tamara Kneese. 2021. Our Silicon Valley, ourselves. <https://www.boundary2.org/2021/08/tamara-kneese-our-silicon-valley-ourselves/>
- [7] Rida Qadri and Noopur Raval. 2021. Mutual Aid Stations. <https://logicmag.io/distribution/mutual-aid-stations/>
- [8] Norman Makoto Su, Amanda Lazar, and Lilly Irani. 2021. Critical Affects: Tech Work Emotions Amidst the Techlash. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 5, CSCW1 (2021), 1–27.

- [9] Richmond Y Wong. 2021. Tactics of Soft Resistance in User Experience Professionals' Values Work. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 5,

CSCW2 (2021), 1–28.